

Taos leadership

Finding Peter Cavill, a technically-minded figure with clout in the City, in charge of the innovative parallel-atomic operating system Taos may be a surprise.

But Cavill is intimately involved in several development projects, some of which are attracting Esprit funding. He is now bidding Taos as an off-the-shelf solution for projects which were expected to run for five years just to get the specifications defined. He also believes the software will save several companies who have bid Transputer-based solutions to complex graphics contracts, and originally thought they needed the extra power of the still-unavailable T900 upgrade. And it'll run on Itanium any processor.

You may hear little about Taos for another year or two, but I think it will shake the silicon towers of Intel and Motorola before 1995.

Peddle's new pet scheme

There would have been no Apple and no Pet, without Chuck Peddle, who designed the 6502 that powered both those prehistoric personal computers; so when Chuck says he has set up in business again, people listen.

This time, he said tantalisingly little: he's setting up a distribution organisation, and has the cheapest RAM SIMMs, the cheapest hard disks for both Apple and PC and the cheapest tape backups on the market. This time, his company is called THSYme and, this time, he will succeed.

Behind the decision to make a profit buying and selling lies a strong desire to prove that you can match technological innovation with financial and commercial innovation.

It's Peddle's theory that before he launches his latest blue-sky whizz-bang technology, he must have access to the retail market. And he also feels that the retail market is suffering badly from a shortage of things to sell for profit. So Chuck is providing it with cheap compo-

nents, and a system-building service, headquartered in Paris. THSYme has a huge catalogue of bits and pieces.

Possibly, he's right. I can recall, if he doesn't, that he had "access to the US market" when he launched Sirius, because he had Victor in his pocket as US distributor. Then, it was the biggest US chain of calculator shops. And it almost totally failed to sell a single Sirius in the US—Peddle was eventually forced to buy Victor out in order to stop Victor undercutting Sirius in the UK and Europe.

It's no secret that for the last five years Peddle's been looking at parallel, cheap systems with fast inter-processor communications, things vaguely like Transputers, but much cheaper. The question is: what would you build with lego-blocks like that?

I would suggest some kind of ultra-lightweight system, hopefully with a clever client-server communications structure built in. We'll see what he actually does, when he actually does it; I'd predict an announcement before summer 1992.

News bits

Elonex's 33MHz SX

Elonex has announced a 33MHz version of the 386SX, which is the first PC from a name manufacturer to offer 33MHz performance at under £1,000. The price tag comes on a 2Mb RAM system with 50Mb disk, colour Super VGA monitor, including mouse, Windows 3.0 and Dos 5.0. Model number: PC-3304.

NeXT developments

Motorola's own design RISC is not dead after all; former Apple chairman Steve Jobs, now running NeXT, says he'll put the 88110 CPU into a RISC workstation before the end of the year. More significant for users of the UK version of this non-standard PC are rumours of a 486 coprocessor in NeXT machinery. No date is given for release of the board; I gather it may cost under £1,000.

Multituser DOS

Novell has announced its multituser DR-DOS 5.1 for those who use applications where shared data is paramount. Up to 16 NetWare sessions can run through a single NetWare adapter board.

Random multimedia

For £500, a multimedia home machine, announced by Random of Cambridge, its key component is no video. Instead, it outputs to a home TV. For your money you get a 386SX in a keyboard-style console. It has room for two half-length cards—typically a video and a LAN controller. Included is a disk controller for IDE and floppy but no hard disk; 1Mb of RAM upgradeable to a maximum 16Mb; two serial, one parallel sockets. Key is an Ad Lib simulator with built-in games port, VGA, and TV driver. Speakers are extra.

Notes on Lotus versus Borland

In March, a judge refused to decide the issue between Lotus 1-2-3 and Borland's Quattro, saying that the matter would have to be heard in court. Both Lotus and Borland immediately rushed out statements pointing out how beneficial this was for them.

The issues are far from simple; Quattro uses some commands designed to be familiar to users of Lotus 1-2-3 spreadsheets. Lotus says this infringes intellectual property rights. The arguments range from highly complex debates about software copyright and patent, to abuse and imaginative analogies about motor cars and clutch pedals.

Having listened to Lotus's lawyers debate the court non-decision for an hour, I was interested to ask Lotus what it would actually do, if a judge and a jury found in their favour. Would the company change Borland a fan-

tasy in royalties? Or would it try to close Borland's spreadsheet operation down?

The question is a simple one; does Lotus want a world where people can improve on other people's inventions, as long as they acknowledge copyright and pay for it? Or does it want to prevent the advance of software technology except by itself?

I'm sorry to say that Lotus told me, in so many words, that it was "not interested" in any kind of royalty deal. "We want them to stop."

Meanwhile, a court decision can make a shift in share price for either company; they could lose, or paper, enough money to pay for the takeover of a small, enterprising software company with new ideas. Hence the need to spend enormous resources presenting a legal non-decision in the best possible light for all sides involved.

I find it sad that the only piece of actual software Lotus has produced, internally, in the last five years is Notes.

On the lawsuit, Lotus went to the trouble of setting up a world-wide simultaneous phone press conference. I got my question answered within two hours.

Yet I have some technical questions on Notes; as a user of Notes, I posted these questions on the Notes conference database of the New York user group. The database is one which is "replicated" by Lotus itself. A month later I discovered that nobody in New York—or indeed in Windsor, for that matter—had read my questions. Lotus had not bothered to replicate the database.

For me, that says more about where the company's energy and attention is focused, than any amount of bragging about size and turnover.